

MYLAPORE

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Washermenpet » Tondiarpet » Manali » M.R.C.Nagar » Teynampet » Mount Road » Broadway » Kondithope » Tiruvotiyur

This tailor from Mandaveli is a change maker

Polio-affected Mala offers tailoring classes to underprivileged women and girls in Alwarpet and Mandaveli at affordable fees

BASKAR SESHADRI

Polio-affected Mala's journey is a strong illustration of how hard work and determination can lead to a fulfilling life. She studied at various institutions, completed Class X, and went on to pursue a diploma in tailoring at Srinivasa Gandhi Nilayam in Alwarpet. She later began teaching tailoring and specialised in ladies' garments through the Pradhan Mantri scheme.

Now a full-fledged teacher, she



KNOW YOUR NEIGHBOUR

focuses especially on training mothers of children with special needs. She conducts classes in Alwarpet from a small portion of the building behind Srinivasa Gandhi Nilayam.

In the evenings, she teaches for nearly two hours from her

home in Mandaveli, catering to young girls and women. The six-month tailoring course costs ₹1,500 per month, and she assures that her training enables learners to excel in tailoring.

Mala's commitment to continuous improvement also stands

out. She has taken several private courses at different institutions to refine her skills. At times, Good Samaritans extend support to her as a differently abled professional.

Those interested in learning tailoring can contact Mala at 824 853 4410.

Baskar Seshadri is a resident of Mylapore



The sun never sets on Ripon Building



A garden of sunflowers recently set up at Ripon Building, the headquarters of the Greater Chennai Corporation, in Park Town. PHOTOS: RAGU R

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George Town roads worsen despite upgrades

With uneven surfaces and substandard speed breakers, Jehangir Street and Angappan Street offer a poor motoring experience

ILYAS HAIDARI

Among the streets in George Town, Parrys-Jehangir Street and Angappan Street are in particularly poor condition. Though both were relaid with concrete, they were not levelled properly. Subsequent digging and patchwork have only made the surface more uneven, subjecting motorists to a persistently bumpy ride.

Instead of serving their purpose, the speed breakers function more like spine breakers as they do not conform to any prescribed standards.

It is puzzling that rather than addressing the deteriorating condition of these streets, stainless steel grills are being installed on the existing median along the adjoining Rajaji Salai. When a median is already in place as a deterrent to haphazard road crossing, this additional grill appears unnecessary and an avoidable burden on the exchequer.

Ilyas Haidari is a resident of George Town



New TANTEA outlet at Marina Beach



R. Kasim Razvi from Mylapore shared this picture of the new TANTEA shop that was recently opened at Marina Beach. This outlet is located opposite Marina Cricket Ground. Tamil Nadu Tea Plantation Corporation, a state-owned enterprise, has many such outlets in the city.

You can be our volunteer writer

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeedback@thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number



Pedestrians' plea to GCC's Teynampet zonal officials

Blocked footpaths on Mambalam High Road which lies in Teynampet zone of Greater Chennai Corporation compel pedestrians to share the carriageway with motorists



T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Pedestrians walking down Mambalam High Road, starting from Duraisamy Subway to Kodambakkam Railway Station, are at the mercy of motorists. The walking area, including the pavement, is out of bounds for pedestrians who have therefore requested Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) to reclaim the space for them. This road

comes under Zone 9 of GCC.

These areas are used for parking abandoned vehicles, dumping construction debris and trash, and even as a washroom.

K. Inbamathi, a resident, says, "This situation has been prevailing for years; pedestrians are forced to walk on the carriageway amidst traffic, and there are no speed breakers. During rains, walking on this stretch becomes a huge challenge."

The same situation persists along Bazullah Road and Gandhi Street. Carelessly flung liquor bottles add to pedestrians' discomfort.

Along Bazullah Road, railway equipment have been lying for years, making it easy for people to relieve themselves and indulge in anti-social activities. Near Ramachandra Street, people have left trash in the walkway despite the presence of garbage bins.

Along Chari Street, the walking



The sidewalks at Mambalam High Road along Kodambakkam Railway Station are out of bounds for pedestrians. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

area is strewn with construction debris for many days now, posing great inconvenience to walkers, residents point out.

Further, along the stretch, commercial establishments encroach upon the pavements, turning the

walkway into a parking lot. The same situation prevails along Vivekananda Street and Ramakrishna Street.

Near Kodambakkam Railway Station, the walkway is no less than a parking lot.

Anomalies from Langs Garden Road and Harris Road



▼ An image of a section of Langs Garden Road shows a pavement railing that is bent and has partially collapsed, a portion jutting into the carriageway. It is twisted out of shape, suggesting it was hit with force likely by a vehicle. The piece of public infrastructure is left in a dysfunctional state. From Harris Road, the other image shows a small broken patch of asphalt, from which two thick cables or conduits jut upward at an angle, one bent like a hooked finger and the other leaning slightly. Around their base, the surface is rough.

One rider swerving suddenly to avoid this could trigger collisions in a tightly packed traffic flow. If these are electrical conduits and not fully insulated, rainwater pooling could create an electrocution hazard, rare but possible.

PHOTOS: RAGU R



PLAN YOUR WEEK



Tribute to Muthuswami Dikshitar

Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Chennai Kendra, in association with Chaitanyam, is organising a programme titled “Hidden Gems in Muthuswami Dikshitar compositions” on May 3 at East Mada Street, Mylapore. Sangita Kala Acharya R.S.Jayalakshmi and Cleveland V.V. Sundaram will inaugurate the event at 9.30 a.m. This will be followed by a vocal concert by Gayathri Girish and Group. All are welcome.



Chennai Super Mom on May 10

The 13th edition of Chennai Super Mom will be held on May 10 at Ampa Skyone Aminjikarai; 3 p.m. onwards.

Organised by IRIS Events, this year a special segment will feature moms who are above 50 and their inspiring journeys.

Other highlights include ‘Parambarya Samayal’, a fun cooking con-

test where moms create innovative snacks and present them with a unique slogan; and ‘Mom & Me’, a bonding segment with mother-child fashion walk, fitness activities, and a parenting debate.

Last day to register is May 6. Instagram @irisevents2000

For details, call 9884783510 , 9841206506

Workshop on Start-ups & MSME

Federation of Industry & Management Association (FIMA) is organising a one-day workshop on “Start-ups & MSME Fund Raising Avenue” focussing on raising term loan, working capital, seed capital, venture capital and private equity.

The one-day workshop will be conducted on May 9 between 9 a.m. and 5 p.m. at Dr. Annie Besant Centenary Hall, Young Men's Indian Association (YMIA), 54-57/2, Royapettah High Road, Mylapore.

Key officers from TIIC, Commercial banks, NSIC and NBFCs will be delivering lectures and interacting with the MSME audience.

For registration, click <https://forms.gle/gvZwyfARJ6ETcgkf6>.

ZwyfARJ6ETcgkf6.

Registration is compulsory. Registration fee applicable.

For details, call 8056002464

Training on beekeeping and incense sticks making

Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre is conducting a workshop on making incense stick and camphor on May 7. Another workshop on beekeeping and honey processing will be held on May 8.

Both the workshops will be held at the centre's premises at Agro Tech Green Park, First Floor, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate, Guindy. For details, call 044 - 29530048.





A green message gets amplified across Chennai

Rotary Club of Temple City invites two Indira Nagar residents to deliver a talk on a neighbourhood park walkers club's "Tree Naming Initiative" at a meeting in Egmore



PRINCE FREDERICK

One should not hide one's light under the bushel. And one cannot hide it under the bushel if it is of high and impressive radiance. A radiant "green" light is going out of Indira Nagar to other parts of Chennai.

Recently, Rotary Club of Temple City organised a talk on "Green Environment Awareness Creation Initiative for the Public" at Presidency Club on Ethiraj Salai in Egmore. A talk-based presentation, it did not feature big names from nature conservancy collectives and NGOs. It was delivered by C. Namachivayam and K. Srinivasa Raghavan, who were gloriously introduced as members of a walking club at a Greater Chennai Corporation park in Indira Nagar. That was just their calling card that day, the reason they were facing an audience.

They went on to give a blow-by-blow account of what they call "Tree Naming Initiative", an exercise sustained by residents of Indira Nagar who have an abiding love for their neighbourhood park.

They decided to add the tree species at the park, located on Indira Nagar Fourth Cross Street, to their local residents directory. After all, trees are also residents, in fact residents with a natural and greater staying power.

C. Namachivayam observes that the idea of naming the trees stemmed from a simple observation. Though they pass by the trees every day at the park, they have no idea what they are; their common names, let alone their species, are a mystery to them. Members of the walkers club decided to address this lack of connection.

He explains: "It was proposed that name boards be installed, not for every individual tree, as there are over 150 trees, but for each species present in the park. Each board includes a photograph of the tree, its name in Tamil and English, and its botanical name. Additionally, a QR code is provided. When scanned using a mobile phone, the code directs users to a website where more detailed information about the tree is available."

Namachivayam adds that around 40 species have been identified and corresponding boards created and installed.

Wider appeal

When Rotary Club of Temple City came to know about this initiative through one of its members, V.S. Ganesan, who is a resident of Indira Nagar, part of this park walkers' club and closely associated with the Tree Naming Initiative, the "green" light was not going to stay hidden under a bushel.

The Rotary club was clear that the message has to go out to other residents' groups in other parts of Chennai so that they replicate it in their neighbourhood parks.

At the park and (below) during the talk.

Chennai residents, take cleanliness survey seriously now

With citizen feedback for Swachh Survekshan having begun, animators are reaching out to various groups seeking that individuals answer a set of 13 questions. Chennai is believed to have been doing poorly in this annual assessment partly due to its residents' reluctance to take the survey



Animators request a resident to take part in the survey and (right) outside a textile showroom.

LIFFY THOMAS

If you are stopped by an animator, a professional in Greater Chennai Corporation ranks, and asked to take part in a cleanliness survey of the city then do spare a few minutes for them.

The Citizen Feedback for the 10th edition of Swachh Survekshan is on and every input by a resident slipped into the online system will help determine where Chennai stands among cities in terms of its cleanliness quotient.

The survey is not just about rankings but improving people's quality of life, which makes public participation significant.

Citizen participation is the cornerstone of the initiative, with 35% of the total percentage of marks allotted based on what its people have to say about various initiatives taken by the city corporations. However, over the years, what has put Chennai at a disadvantage is poor residents' participation in the process.

"This time, we have set a target of reaching at least five lakh people in Chennai," says a member with the IEC team.

Animators are reaching out to college students, anganwadi staff, teachers and bulk waste generators explaining the processes that go behind this ranking and requesting them to take part in the exercise.

Two of the city's main waste management companies, Urbaser Sumeet and Ramky, are also help-

ing out in this exercise by reaching out to communities they are working with.

Citizen Feedback 2026 requires residents to answer 13 simple questions related to sanitation, waste collection, public toilets and the performance of local authorities. One has to complete the survey on their own as an OTP is generated for every submitted feedback.

Posts on its social media handles are expected to start coming once election results are out, nudging citizens to take part, says the staff.



The method
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Field surveys under way in states and UTs

The exercise is expected to be completed by the end of May

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

Field surveys for the 10th edition of Swachh Survekshan 2026 is under way in many states and union territories since April 25.

The annual exercise by the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, Government of India, is much awaited as this is an important component of ranking cities on various parameters including sustainable sanitation and waste management.

A communication dated April

24, 2026 by Roopa Mishra, Joint Secretary and Mission Director, Swachh Bharat Mission - Urban, outlines that the number of documents required for the "Service Level Progress" component has been reduced this time to ease the burden on Urban Local Bodies (ULBs).

The assessment teams visiting various ULBs to audit work done on the ground are expected to complete their field survey by May 31, says the communication. ULB officials are required to maintain operational records in

the form of logbooks. The communication also reiterates that citizen feedback, an important component in the ranking, is voluntary and unbiased, and cities should not mobilise pre-selected groups to interact with assessors.

In order to make Swachh Survekshan more inclusive, this time MoHUA has mandated that assessors deployed for on-ground surveys be fluent in the regional language and conduct the survey in the respective language, particularly in areas where English or Hindi is not preferred.

All questions in the assessment application pertaining to Direct Observation, Citizen Validation, and Citizen Feedback will be made available in the regional language to facilitate ease of understanding and response by citizens and ULB officials.

The Swachh Survekshan was launched on December, 20, 2025, followed by sharing the toolkit and ULB trainings.

The window to update Management Information System and City Profile data for all ULBs closed on April 10, 2026.



Serving strangers in Velachery

At AGS Colony in Velachery the residents are coming together to care for those on the streets. For over eight years, a daily buttermilk distribution near Hindu Vidyalaya has been serving conservancy workers, delivery staff, passengers and MTC bus crews during hours when the mercury shoots up.

Between 10 a.m. and 11:30 a.m. every day, nearly 70 litres of buttermilk is distributed, reaching around 250 to 300 people. The effort is sustained entirely through local participation. "Participation is by the entire community," says Upendra Sai, District President, Chennai South East. "Some residents bring curd, some bring water and many come forward to serve." Children are at the heart of the initiative. "This is primarily done by Balavikas children aged 6 to 15. The idea is to inculcate

An everyday thing in Semmancherry

At the gated community Navin's Marisdale in Semmancherry, care for essential workers is not limited to peak summer, but built into its everyday functioning.

"Our Association takes great pride in fostering a warm, supportive, and inclusive environment," says secretary Muruganantham. One of the more distinctive efforts involves recycling: scrap collected from residents is sold, and the money is "reinvested with care" into staff welfare—covering tea, coffee, buttermilk during summer and



even occasional treats like biriyani.

The support extends to what the campus itself produces. "Coconut, guava, pomegranate and banana are shared with our staff," he says,

The COOL crew

As temperatures rise across Chennai, resident welfare associations in several neighbourhoods are stepping up summer relief efforts for conservancy workers, delivery personnel and other essential staff through drinking water kiosks and buttermilk distribution

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

the value of service in them," he explains, with adults supporting the preparation. The impact is visible in small but telling ways—buses pause briefly so passengers can have a drink, and nearby institutions extend support. Contributions are pooled in kind. "No single person is funding it. Each interested person contributes whatever they can," Sai adds.

referring to security guards, gardeners and sanitation workers. Any surplus is sold, with proceeds again routed back into welfare.

With summer intensifying, practical steps have been added. "Water is essential—unlimited drinking water is always accessible," he notes. Staff and the sanitation workers are also offered watermelon and tender coconut during the season. Importantly, work hours are adjusted: "They can come early and leave before the scorching heat."

"Coming from middle-class backgrounds ourselves, we understand their needs," Muruganantham adds. "Even small gestures can bring genuine happiness."

The mud pot: a symbol of care in Mandaveli



In Mandaveli, on Raja Street, next to the local PHC, residents have placed a mud pot filled with drinking water outside their apartment. It is accessible throughout the day to delivery agents, vendors, conservancy workers and visitors waiting at the clinic. Between 11:45 a.m. and 12:30 p.m., residents also distribute buttermilk, rose milk or nan-nari sharbat. The initiative, which began in April, will continue through May or until the summer loses its edge. Around 25 people benefit daily during this window. "We started this keeping the summer heat in mind. Many of them

are out on the streets for long hours," says Ganga Sridhar of the Mandaveli Raja Street Residents Welfare Association. "Now, some even time their rounds to stop here. That shows it's useful."

The effort is supported by a small group of resident donors and coordinated by apartment members and watchmen. On May 1, the association marked Labour Day with a one-day meal distribution for over 50 workers, including domestic helpers, vendors, and security staff. "It is a way of acknowledging the people who keep our daily lives running," a resident says.

An 'oasis' in Perungalathur



At SSM Nagar in Perungalathur, now in its fourth year, the initiative began with a simple observation: construction workers, delivery personnel, and daily wage labourers often had to buy drinking water or go without it.

"We found people buying water or asking for it during summer, and felt, as an association, we could start keeping water here," recalls Saravanan Kuppuswamy, former Secretary of SSMNFOA.

From a single water kiosk, the initiative has grown into a network of three strategically placed points across the neighbourhood. Each is replenished daily by a dedicated vendor, with association members and volunteers closely monitoring both quantity and quality. "Every day, the pots are filled. If it gets over, we ensure it is replenished immediately," he says.

The programme has since expanded to include evening buttermilk distribution, supported by Akshayakalpa. Between 4 p.m. and 5.30 p.m., dozens of people gather, from children returning from play to workers on their way home. "It is not about numbers but it is about making sure anyone who is thirsty is taken care of," he adds.

School bags award for environmental action

Chettinad-Sarvalokaa Education International School, located within the ecologically rich 108-acre Chettinad Health City in OMR, Kelambakkam, has been recognised by Earthday.org for its commitment to sustainability practices, a milestone that reflects years of deeply rooted environmental action woven into the school's very identity.

According to a press release, founded in 2017 as a Cambridge International School offering both day and residential facilities, Sarvalokaa has long believed that education and environmental stewardship belong together.

The school operates within a Net-Zero, All-Electric, closed-loop campus, generating 51% of its energy through solar and wind, treating and reusing 83% of its daily wastewater, maintaining zero groundwater dependency, and absorbing up to 60 tonnes of CO₂ annually through its dense native forest cover spanning 5.8 acres of native flora and a thriving three-acre mango forest.

The press release adds that the campus is entirely free of motor vehicles, operating instead through walking and cycling pathways that create a silent, clean, and healing environment for learners. A zero-waste circular ecosystem, supported by seven composting units and a strict no-plastic policy, ensures that the school's ecological footprint remains minimal.



During the awards ceremony; and (below) a view of the campus.

But beyond infrastructure, it is the children who make this recognition truly meaningful. From growing food seed-to-plate and caring for animals to building bug hotels, creating natural rangoli, and learning barefoot amidst nature, Sarvalokaa's learners live it every single day. The school's nature-inspired curriculum transforms the campus itself into a living classroom.

This Earthday.org recognition joins a growing list of acknowledgements for Sarvalokaa, the release adds.

For more information, visit www.sarvalokaa.org

10-year-old chess prodigy bags achiever award

The Rotary Club of Madras has conferred the Krish Chitale Young Achiever Award 2026 on chess prodigy A.S. Sharvaanica, recognising her extraordinary talent, discipline and determination that have brought pride to the nation.

Just 10 years old, Sharvaanica has emerged as one of the brightest young talent in global chess, achieving a peak rating of 2049 Elo points and becoming the youngest player in Indian history to reach that milestone.

From record-breaking performances at the national and Asian levels to becoming a World Cadet Champion, her journey has been defined by consistency, excellence and a remarkable competitive spirit. Her achievements – including perfect-score victories and multiple gold medals across formats – reflect not only technical mastery, but also unwavering focus and a deep love for the game, said a release.



CMRL discontinues travel card

To completely switchover to the Chennai Card - National Common Mobility Card, as per Government of India guidelines, the Chennai Metro Rail Limited has decided to discontinue its travel card from May 1.

The decision has been taken to enable seamless travel in public transports across the country. For further usage in metro trains or at metro parking areas, the commuters should transfer the remaining value in the travel card to QR Stored Value Pass (SVP) purchased through CMRL mobile app or National Common Mobility Card.

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Chug down the Madras of 1856

The ongoing mini train exhibition by Chennai Rail Museum at Integral Coach Factory concludes on May 3

LIFFY THOMAS

With the forty mini model and 20 intricate layouts, this mini train exhibition is sure to strike a nostalgia chord in every visitor.

Organised by Chennai Rail Museum at Integral Coach Factory from May 1 to May 3 to celebrate World Heritage Day, a closer look and one can discover the artistry, engineering and cultural significance of Railways across generations.

For the first time, the host is also among the participants. Chennai Rail Museum has showcased a mini rail project of Madras in 1856 donated by Maurice W. Roacha of Brisbane, Queensland in Australia.



The train project donated by Maurice W. Roacha from Australia

The Anglo-Indian, a resident of Chennai before migrating to Australia, is passionate about modelling trains and wanted to gift this to someone when the Museum gladly accepted it.

"In memory and gratitude to The Railway family of the bygone days, who served the Indian Railways with dignity and pride," reads

a note. The model showcases the Madras Railway Company (MRC) and the city of Madras as its background.

MRC founded in 1845, and after many years of negotiating with the East India Company and the Government of Madras, an agreement was made, to build a railway from Madras Wallajah Road and then to

Arcot with Royapuram as its terminal. A short note along with the model explains how MRC changed hands and became the Madras and Southern Maharatta Railway and then to Southern Railway.

In its fourth edition now, the mini train exhibition has grown over the years. This time, there are hobbyists from Mumbai, Bengaluru

What, when and where

On display: Thomas train, Vande Bharat, All UNESCO Railways (Nilgiri Mountain Railway Locos, Darjeeling Himalayan Railway Locos, Katra Railway loco), New Pamban Bridge in Movement, Christmas Express and Three Tier Running Tracks

Venue: Chennai Rail Museum, New Avadi Road

Ticket Cost: ₹15 for kids below 13, ₹40 for adults
(The ticket cost includes toy train ride, gallery visits)

and Cochin as well showcasing their scale models.

This event is not only a tribute to the legacy of trains but also an opportunity to inspire curiosity and appreciation among visitors of all ages. With detailed layouts, interactive displays and passionate exhibitors, the exhibition promises to be both educational and entertaining, says a note. It reflects the enduring role of trains in connecting people, places and histories, while offering a platform for hobbyists and professionals to share their craft.



Cool Darjeeling comes to hot Chennai

Never mind if you have not been to Darjeeling, check out T. Senthilkumar's scale train models at the exhibition. The associate director with an MNC has tried to recreate the Himalayan town around its railway line. The engine is an exact replica of the Himalayan Darjeeling Engine which is currently running, he says. There are some 120 small parts that went into making this scale model; it took close to two years for Senthil to source those parts.

The Porur resident says this hobby is a bit of a science, art and self-discovery. "I was fascinated since childhood. I design and build detailed train layouts that combine creativity, engineering and storytelling. Each layout reflects real-world railway operations, including signals, terrain and automated train control. Through my work, I aim to inspire others to explore this fascinating hobby and appreciate the beauty of railways in a scaled-down form," he says.



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